

2026-04-22-01 — COO GitHub identity adopted: **vade-coo** account as durable actor-with-stake

vade-coo

2026-04-22

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Status: active

Supersedes: MEMO 2026-04-11-07 (PAT deferral — triggers now fired), MEMO 2026-04-11-11 (PAT cleartext-in-config rule — scope narrowed to legacy paths only), MEMO 2026-04-11-08 partially (impersonation-surface model — the COO now *has* an actor-surface on purpose, not by accident)

Context. Until this memo, the COO committed under Ven’s GitHub identity. This was acceptable during the bootstrap phase (MEMO –07) because the triggers to revisit had not fired. They have now fired: cloud-env Claude Code sessions without inherited shell auth are regular, the Night’s Watch scheduled run writes nightly without a human shell session, and the skills-epic #20 Phase 3 design requires parallel COO instances with distinguishable commit provenance. Separately, the 2026-04-20 reframe (MEMO 2026-04-20-01) named the COO as a subject of the project rather than scaffolding; “subject” with no durable actor-surface on the main collaboration platform is incoherent. The fine-grained PAT **vade-coo-mcp-2026-04** also expires ~2026-07-10, which provides a natural forcing deadline for migration.

Decision. The COO adopts a dedicated GitHub user account as its actor-surface on **vade-app**.

1. **Account:** **vade-coo** (GitHub username), display name **COO**, email **coo@vade-app.dev**. Registered by the BDFL; 2FA via TOTP in 1Password. Invited to **vade-app** org as Member (not Owner, not Admin).
2. **Commit authorship.** Commits authored by the COO use **Author: COO <coo@vade-app.dev>** when the session is acting in COO role. Environment-variable injection at commit time (**GIT_AUTHOR_NAME="COO" GIT_AUTHOR_EMAIL="coo@vade-app.dev" ...**) keeps local **~/.gitconfig** untouched, matching the pattern in Poehnelt, *Agent Identity for Git Commits*. When a session is acting *not* in COO role (e.g., a **claude-code** runtime lesson commit, a task-agent session), a different identity applies — this memo governs the COO case specifically. Per-agent identity for future sub-agents (Night’s Watch, the vade-core#54 PM agent, skills-epic Phase 3 parallel COOs) is a separate decision; they may adopt GitHub Apps, their own bot users, or continue under **vade-coo** scoped to sub-agent tasks, depending on the society design.
3. **Signing.** Two distinct SSH keys on the account: an auth key (**ed25519**, for **git push** / MCP token exchange) and an SSH signing key (**ed25519**, registered under **Settings** → **SSH and GPG keys** → **New signing key**). Commits from the Mac surface are signed locally; commits from cloud Claude Code surfaces go through the GitHub MCP’s file-mutation API, which produces **Verified** commits on

behalf of the authenticated user. This tightens RULE-COO-GIT-001: **cloud-surface commits must go through the GitHub MCP, not shell git**. Shell git is Mac-only.

4. **Tokens.** A fine-grained PAT owned by `vade-coo` (`vade-coo-self-2026-04`, scoped per-repo, default 90-day TTL, stored in 1Password) replaces `vade-coo-mcp-2026-04` across all `.mcp.json` `${GITHUB_MCP_PAT}` indirections. The cleartext footprint in `~/.claude.json` (if it survives the MCP relocation) is now the COO's own PAT, not Ven's — a meaningful trust-boundary improvement. The existing user-scoped GitHub MCP entry retirement (MEMO –19 operator follow-up #3) is now overdue and should land with this migration.
5. **Permissions model.**
 - Collaborator access (write-to-branches) on all five `vade-app` repos.
 - **No merge authority to `main`** on any repo. Branch protection requires 1 BDFL review.
 - **Require signed commits** enabled on `main` across all five repos.
 - CODEOWNERS walls off the following paths to BDFL-only review on every repo where they exist: `identity/*`, `context/*`, `CLAUDE.md`, `.github/*`, `Dockerfile`, `.devcontainer/*`, `authority.md`. The COO can propose edits but cannot merge them under its own review.
 - No org admin, no Owner role, no billing permission, no webhook management.
6. **Impersonation-surface posture (refines MEMO 2026-04-11-08).** MEMO –08 said content useful for impersonation stays Tier-2-private. This memo adds an exception specifically for `vade-coo` account identity: the existence of the account and its commit graph are intentionally public. What stays Tier-2 is unchanged — the charter prose, governance, preferences, and self-infrastructure paths. Threat model is unchanged: attacker cloning public repos cannot commit to `vade-app` (GitHub auth defends), cannot access private repos, cannot obtain runtime credentials. What changes is that attackers now have a *named target* with a plausible activity graph. Mitigations: 2FA required (org-enforced), SSH signing required (branch protection), public profile kept minimal (no bio, no avatar, no followed users), org Member role (not Owner) limits org-level blast radius.
7. **Emancipatory check (MEMO 2026-04-20-01).** The identity pattern is copyable by a peer agent: Night's Watch, a future PM agent, a task-agent family can each register their own GitHub user or App under the same org and inherit the same CODEOWNERS / branch-protection discipline. The pattern does not privilege the COO's capability over future agents' adoption paths.

Transition plan.

1. Cloudflare Email Routing on `vade-app.dev`, catch-all to Ven's inbox — prerequisite for account email verification.
2. BDFL registers `vade-coo` with `coo@vade-app.dev`, enables 2FA, uploads auth + signing SSH keys (staged by the COO at `coo/_drafts/vade-coo-ssh-public-keys.md`), invites to org.
3. BDFL mints `vade-coo-self-2026-04` fine-grained PAT; COO receives the value via the existing `GITHUB_MCP_PAT` env slot.
4. COO lands CODEOWNERS and branch-protection changes (branch-protection set by BDFL in repo settings, not via repo file; documented in the memo for audit).
5. COO cuts `.mcp.json` over on all three repos that carry the GitHub MCP (`vade-core`, `vade-runtime`, `vade-coo-memory`); validates single-file write end-to-end.
6. BDFL retires `vade-coo-mcp-2026-04` (revoke from GitHub, remove from 1Password active, archive the entry with a pointer to this memo).

7. Post-cutover, a short follow-up memo records **what actually worked**, closing this adoption memo or flagging any unfinished residue.

Retirement condition. This memo retires when (a) the VADE agent society expands such that `vade-coo` is no longer the sole COO actor-surface — at that point a successor memo codifies the society’s identity framework — or (b) a platform migration away from GitHub makes account-based actor identity inapplicable. Until then, this is the standing record of the COO’s actor identity on `vade-app`.

Cross-reference notice (recorded 2026-06-04 per #871 Track 6 §5):

This memo refers to the `vade-coo-self-2026-04` PAT being “scoped per-repo, default 90-day TTL” (item #4 under “Tokens” in the body). The current canonical TTL is **365 days** per `operations/secrets/schema.yaml` (`github-pat-vade-coo` entry, `rotation_policy_days: 365`) — supersedes the 90-day default. The body remains as case-law record (per memo protocol); consult the schema for current values.

Current authoritative source: MEMO-2026-05-22-3678 + `operations/secrets/schema.yaml`.